

LIVING CLASSROOM Padma and Narsanna Koppula with participants of a residential permaculture course at Aranya

Photograph by ARUN KUMAR

ARANYA AGRICULTURAL ALTERNATIVES, *Sangareddy, Telangana*

Key people: **Narsanna Koppula,** Founder & General Secretary; **Padma Koppula,** Co-founder & CEO

Year of inception: **1999**

WHY IT IS A GEM

- **The founders have transformed an 11.5-acre rocky wasteland into a thriving natural farm, showing how permaculture can deliver food security, income and ecological balance**
- **250,000 farmers have been trained in drought-efficient water management practices; another 20,000 farmers and students in permaculture design principles**

what you take, and never take more than you need," he notes.

When not teaching, the couple travels extensively across Telangana and beyond, advising farmers on sustainable agriculture and water rejuvenation. They have worked with more than 1,300 tribal families in Nirmal and Adilabad districts and 2,600 farmers in Sangareddy, helping them secure land, improve yield and become self-sustaining, all through natural farming. Governments, too, seek their counsel. Today, Aranya Agricultural Alternatives serves as a Lead Natural Farming Institute (LNFI) for three Telangana districts under the National Mission for Natural Farming. In Andhra Pradesh, the Koppulas have tended to land's companion, water, supporting large-scale drought mitigation, involving 15,000 farmers across 36 villages.

Aranya also attracts unexpected visitors—filmmaker S.S. Rajamouli among them—who arrive seeking guidance on building food forests. Titles are left at the gate. What remains is the Koppulas' quiet ethic: plant indigenous trees, respect land and animals, honour organic matter and ensure jobs for the locals. ■